CLOUD & DEVOPS

Incident Response Visual Guide

Sev levels, roles, runbooks —
calm, practiced, repeatable firefighting.

ANIMATED WALKTHROUGH
Step through pages to play the animation

STEP 1/6

Severity Levels

Sev defines urgency, responders, and comms — decided in minutes.

SEV-1

critical: full outage / data loss — all hands, exec comms

SEV-2

major: core feature down — on-call + team lead

SEV-3

minor: degraded, workaround exists — owning team

SEV-4

low: cosmetic / single user — backlog it

Declare the SEV early and adjust later. Under-sevving delays help; over-sevving just wastes a few people's hour.

STEP 2/6

Roles: Who Does What

Named roles prevent five people debugging and nobody communicating.

Incident Commander

owns the response: decides, delegates, declares 'all clear'

Comms Lead

status page + stakeholder updates every 15–30 min

Ops / Responders

diagnose and mitigate — report to the IC

Scribe

timeline of everything: the postmortem writes itself

The IC doesn't debug — they coordinate. The moment the IC goes heads-down, the response loses its brain.

STEP 3/6

The Incident Lifecycle

Detect → declare → mitigate → resolve → learn.

Mitigate BEFORE root-causing: roll back, fail over, shed load — understanding can wait.

- Time-to-mitigate is the metric that matters, not time-to-root-cause.
- Declare early: a SEV-2 that becomes SEV-1 wasted 30 minutes of response.
- Resolve = verified fixed + monitoring green, not 'looks fine to me'.

STEP 4/6

Runbooks: Decisions Made in Advance

A good runbook turns panic into procedure.

Runbook: 'Checkout errors spiking'

1. Check payments dashboard → 2. Flip feature flag → 3. Roll back deploy → 4. Page payments on-call

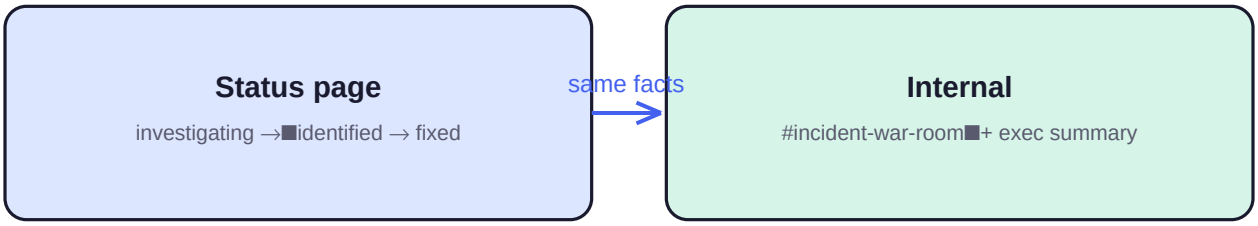
Anatomy: symptoms → diagnosis steps → mitigation actions → escalation paths.

- Link runbooks FROM the alert — the page should land on the procedure.
- Test runbooks in game days: an untested runbook is fiction.
- Keep them short: if it needs 20 pages, automate the first 15.

STEP 5/6

Status Communications

Silence breeds speculation — communicate on a cadence.

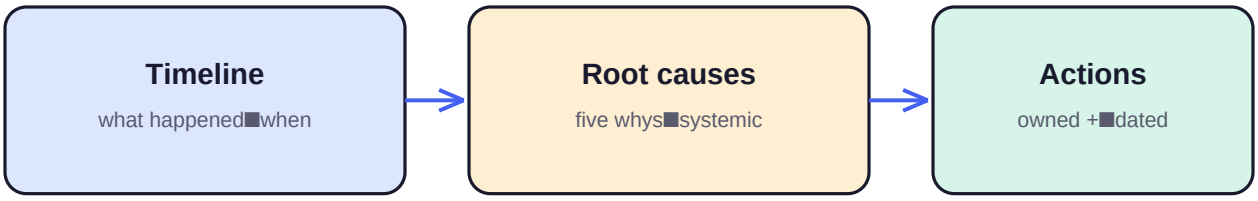


- Update every 15–30 min even if there's nothing new: 'still investigating' beats silence.
- Template: what's broken, who's affected, what we're doing, next update time.
- One voice outward (comms lead); responders stay heads-down.

STEP 6/6

Post-Incident Review

The incident ends twice: when it's fixed, and when it's learned from.



Blameless: 'what let this through?' not 'who did this?' — or the next incident goes unreported.

STEP ✓I✓

Key Takeaways

Incident Response — Remember

- Declare the SEV early; adjust later. Named roles: IC coordinates, comms communicates.
- Mitigate before root-causing — time-to-mitigate is the metric.
- Runbooks linked from alerts turn panic into procedure; test them in game days.
- Communicate on cadence (15–30 min): status page outward, war room inward.
- Blameless postmortem with owned action items — the incident ends when it's learned from.

Keep exploring

Pair this guide with the matching video walkthroughs and hands-on labs at interstitiumlabs.dev